

LUCKNOW | Bailing Out

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In the national capital of crime, what could anticipatory bail possibly do? Well, we'll find out, thanks to a PIL. The Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court has signalled its approval towards introducing anticipatory bail, which does not exist under the current law. The Uttar Pradesh cabinet had earlier approved the decision after a report by BSP General Secretary Satish Mishra.

MISHRA WITH MAYAWATI

Pradeep Dubey, principal secretary, Legislative Assembly, who was also a part of the Mishra Committee, said it would decrease the number of cases and bring down harassment of citizens. Cases of terrorism, secessionism and anti-national activities have been kept out. But the decision has a dangerous flip side too.

Senior advocate I.B. Singh says the Government should think about its long-term ramifications because, "more than 157 MLAs face criminal charges and the conviction rate in heinous crimes is not even 10 per cent". Experts feel it may skew the criminal justice system, which rarely favours the poor in the state. Mayawati may need a rethink on this issue.

by Subhash Mishra

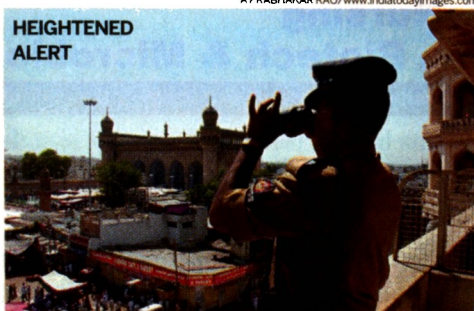
BUZZ
OF THE WEEK

Congressmen are trying to decipher Sonia Gandhi's latest missive. In party mouthpiece *Sandesh*, she writes about both addressing terror and the root cause of Naxalism. Whose line is she advocating, Chidambaram's or Digvijay's, they ask.

HYDERABAD | Off Guard

Hyderabad's securitymen are being selectively targeted. Gunmen on two-wheelers have for the third time in three years attacked men in uniform in broad daylight and escaped. There is a deepening suspicion that the strikes are the handiwork of a SIMI activist-turned-LET operative Syed Vicaruddin. The targeting of the police is seen as revenge for the police action in 2007 at the Mecca Masjid.

A counter intelligence officer who was trying to nab Vicaruddin on December 3, 2008 was fired at; then home guard Balaswamy on the second anniversary of the Mecca Masjid blasts in 2009 and constable U. Ramesh of the Andhra Pradesh Special Police on May 14 this year. A be-



leaguered city police has formed a special investigation team to identify the assailants. With no clues, the police are posting armed pickets at sensitive spots and providing bulletproof vests for their men who were on duty at the Mecca Masjid in 2007.

by Amarnath K. Menon

DELHI | The Sphinx

India's indigenous main battle tank Arjun is on a roll. From being declared overweight and comatose last year, it successfully squared off in comparative trials against the army's Russian-made T-90 Bhishma main battle tank this year. The army will shortly order a second batch of 124 Arjuns to be delivered over the next four years. The new batch of Mark 1+ tanks will have explosive-reactive protective armour panels meant to destroy incoming missiles and have the ability to fire missiles through its

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main gun. The Defence Ministry has also given the nod to the development of the ORDO's Arjun-2, a meaner missile-firing tank. Arjun-2 will start rolling off the production line at the Heavy Vehicles Factory Avadi after the batch of 124 tanks. The Arjun's DNA will also be found in the army's future main battle tank which begins development this year. by Sandeep Unnithan